EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Do Jews Believe in Reincarnation?

Given Monday 31 March 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 6:8

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 6 (The Soul), Chapter 8, the end of the essay

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 31 March 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Seven Chapters on the Soul

The final shiur before Pesach. Through the summer, unless otherwise announced, the shiur runs 6 to 7. Tonight finishes the sixth essay.

- **Chapter 1:** the theories of what the soul is, and Saadia's refutations.
- **Chapter 2:** the study of the soul is a very subtle discipline.
- **Chapter 3:** Saadia's view. The soul is **created**, **simultaneously with the body**, a very fine ethereal substance finer than the spheres, which **only works together with the body**. It has several names, and its primary dwelling is the heart.
- **Chapter 4:** why Hashem puts a lofty soul in a lowly body. The body is not necessarily low, and this is the only way the soul can work toward eternal bliss.
- **Chapter 5:** whatever happens to the soul happens to the body in the world to come, and vice versa. Olam HaBa is not for the body alone, the soul alone or the bones alone.
- **Chapter 6: מספר ימים**, a set number of days, which Hashem increases or decreases according to a person's obedience.
- **Chapter 7:** at death a person sees the angel, yellow with blue eyes and an outstretched sword. We cannot see the soul leave because it is transparent. It then waits until Olam HaBa in a kind of waiting room, and its place there corresponds, on a limited level, to the bliss it will have.

Two main parts, then: what the soul is and is not, and what happens to it in and before Olam HaBa. What reward and punishment actually are is a whole essay of its own, Essay 9. Ahead: Essay 7 on resurrection, Essay 8 on Mashiach, Essay 9 on reward and punishment, and Essay 10 on general *musar* and ethics.

Chapter 8 adds "a whole new topic": **gilgul**, reincarnation.

Part 1: Does the Soul Decompose?

Before reincarnation, Saadia adds one paragraph that, the Rabbi said, really belongs at the end of Chapter 7. Having said that the soul waits after death to be rejoined with the body, he now rejects views that hold otherwise.

View 1: the soul decomposes with the body. This follows from the theories in Chapter 1 that the soul is something physical, a fire or a wind, or an **accident** of the body (the five "accident" theories). If the soul is only an accident of the body's creation, then when the body decomposes, so does the soul. If it is physical, it too decomposes with the body.

View 2: the soul returns to its source. Those who held the soul is a spiritual matter that came from God (or from God and something else, or from two deities) believe that after death it returns to where it came from.

Saadia has already shown these theories are mistaken, so we are left with his: the body dies, the soul waits, and the two are combined again for bliss in Olam HaBa at the resurrection.

"A bit of Hashem"?

The Rabbi drew out a point: **Saadia here clearly rejects the idea that the soul is something from Hashem Himself.**

"You ask little children who go to schools what's the neshamah, they'll tell you it's a bit of Hashem. That's literally how they translate it in some schools." According to Saadia, and according to mainstream opinion, that is a totally wrong understanding. The Rabbi said the concept of everyone having a spark of Hashem within him comes from **Chabad**, but "we have to be very careful with using such terminology. Our souls are not a part of Hashem." The idea that Hashem enters into something physical within our essence "is very Christian... it doesn't work like that." Saadia says those who think the soul comes from God and returns to Him are wrong. Rather, the soul is a new creation, simultaneous with the body; while the body decomposes, the soul waits under the wings of the Shechinah, and is rejoined with the resurrected body for eternal bliss.

Part 2: Reincarnation

Defining terms

Saadia does not use the word *gilgul*, which is a later term. He calls it **העתקה**, "copying over," transmigration.

Reincarnation must not be confused with resurrection. Resurrection is a fundamental belief of the Chachamim, of the Rambam and of all Jews; how it will happen is "a conversation for another time," but that there will be a resurrection is accepted. Olam HaBa and Mashiach likewise. "These are all things which are non-negotiable."

Reincarnation is something completely different: a person dies, and while the soul is waiting, "perhaps it's bored or for whatever reason," it comes back down in a new human body, or in an animal; and part of the theory was that an animal's soul could also pass into a human.

Saadia's text

"I found some people who call themselves Jews who believe in transmigration. They say the soul of Reuven can later go into Shimon, and many of them also say that the spirit of a human can go into an animal and the soul of an animal into a human, and more of this nonsense and madness. I thought about what caused them to believe this madness, and I found four primary mistakes."

Why "people who call themselves Jews"? The explanation given is that Saadia means the **Karaites**, one of his main targets throughout the book, who held this belief. He clearly speaks of

them very negatively. Some of his four arguments, the Rabbi warned, are debatable: "not all of them are so smooth."

Mistake 1: It assumes the soul comes from God

Those who believe that a soul leaves one body and enters another are, says Saadia, following those who believe the soul comes from God, from something spiritual. But Saadia holds firmly that the soul is created simultaneously with the body, "so that in itself has already stopped the whole concept of gilgul neshamot, because there is no concept of taking a soul and putting it into a body." Whether the body is "created" at conception or at birth, which was discussed in Chapter 3, the soul is created with it. And since we have already rejected the idea that the soul comes from God Himself, reincarnation falls with it.

The Rabbi's verdict: "That's not so convincing." It is less an argument against reincarnation than a reminder that it rests on a view already rejected.

Mistake 2: Humans resemble animals

People see similarities between humans and animals, "long before evolution." One person is humble like a sheep, another bad like a donkey, one always eating like a dog, another fast like a bird. So, they say, he must have come from a bird, from a dog.

The Rabbi noted that in contemporary Jewish belief in gilgul we hear very little about animal souls coming into humans. We hear of humans coming back as humans, or, "if you're really bad," as animals. In Saadia's time, the two-way traffic was a big belief.

Saadia: "May God have mercy upon them for their stupidity." If the soul of an animal comes into a human, it now functions as a human soul. So the body must have the power to transform its nature, to upgrade it. And when a human soul enters an animal, the body must downgrade it to fit an animal. Yet they also say the soul gives the person animal characteristics while he is still in human form. "So what's in charge?" They both deny that the soul has its own intrinsic nature and contradict themselves.

The Rabbi's analogy from recent experience: try transferring from one kind of phone to another, from a Samsung to an iPhone. "There's so many things you can't do... because it's two different things." Transferring between two iPhones is one thing; between two different systems, much of it does not work. So too between animal and human souls.

Again debatable: "especially if we're only looking at reincarnation of humans into humans, then this argument falls away."

Mistake 3: Why do babies suffer?

"It's a very common claim you hear nowadays." God is omnibenevolent; He does no injustice. So why are babies born with disabilities and terrible diseases, *rachmana litzlan*? It must be that they are suffering for sins committed in a previous body.

Saadia gives two answers.

Answer 1: reward in the future. Saadia already said in Essay 5, when he discussed why the righteous suffer, that suffering can serve to increase a person's reward. The child suffering now will be compensated in the future. The Rabbi noted that this is Saadia's opinion rather than an argument; the **Rambam** rejects that kind of suffering, so for the Rambam, who clearly did not believe in reincarnation either, another explanation of children's suffering is needed.

Answer 2: commanded for the future. "I'm not entirely clear on this. I'll do my best to explain the way I understood it." Ask them about the soul's original state, before it was placed in a human. Was it under commandments then? If not, there can be no punishment, because there was no commandment. If it was, then at that point it had done nothing wrong or right, so it was given commandments **for the future**. If they accept that a soul can be charged with responsibilities looking toward the future, they should also accept that it can suffer now for reward in the future. Either way, a baby's suffering is no proof of a previous life.

Q: What about the sins of the fathers visited on three or four generations? You could read the Torah that way, but not according to the Chachamim's interpretation, which everyone accepts: children suffer for parents' deeds only when they continue those deeds. A baby has not yet done anything. And if you say Hashem is punishing the child for what he will do later, that runs into **Yishmael**, of whom it says **באשר הוא שם**: we are judged for what we are now, not for what we will do. The Rabbi acknowledged the exception of the rebellious son, "the 13-year-old who gets killed," which "is a whole discussion." The general principle remains that a person is punished for what he is doing now.

Mistake 4: Five verses

They bring "dubious sources from the verses." Saadia refutes five.

1. "Those who are not here with us today." Moshe, on the last day of his life, makes the covenant **את אשר ישנו פה עמנו היום... ואת אשר איננו פה עמנו היום**. They said this means those here now and those who will later come in other bodies. "Clearly a nonsensical proof." If it were the same souls, they would already be "with me today." Rather, it means future generations, who will receive these words through tradition and must keep the covenant.

The Rabbi mentioned the famous Midrash that all the souls of Am Yisrael were present at the covenant, the souls in bodies and the souls waiting to enter bodies. Saadia cannot accept that, because he holds there is "no warehouse of souls waiting to be put into bodies." In any case, none of the Rishonim who did believe in gilgul brought a proof from this verse.

2. "Who did not walk." **אשרי האיש אשר לא הלך בעצת רשעים**: why past tense? Because, they say, he is praised for not having sinned in his previous life. Saadia: the verse is praising a constant, present way of life. Proof: the next verse says **ובתורתו יהגה יומם ולילה**, literally "he will study." If you take the tenses literally, he is rewarded for Torah he has not yet learned. The Rabbi added (Saadia implies it but does not say it) that Hebrew often uses past or future for something present and constant. "Lifestyle is a lifestyle in which you don't walk in the path of the wicked, and you study Torah."

3. "It changes like clay." **תתהפך כחומר חותם ויתיצבו כמו לבוש** (Iyov). "The next proof is actually a proof which was brought by some of the Rishonim." Some understood that the **soul** changes like pliable clay from one form to another, and that, said the Rabbi, is how the **Ramban** understood it. Saadia calls this naive. The preceding verse mentions the earth, and it is the **earth** that changes: it will bring forth all kinds of strange and frightening things to punish the wicked, who will be attached to it "like a garment attached to you," unable to shake off their punishment. The **Ibn Ezra** explains the verse the same way.

4. "He restores my soul." **נפשי ישובב** (Tehillim 23). They thought it meant restoring the soul into another body. "Doesn't mean restore me into a new body, it means give me some tranquility...

give me energy back again." Saadia brings a series of verses, and the Rabbi said "he's 100% right here":

- **Shimshon**, thirsty, drank, and **ותשב רוחו ויחי**: he had not died; his energy returned.
- **The Egyptian** whom David fed when he was starving: **ותשב רוחו אליו**.

ונפש אדניו ישיב: a faithful messenger restores his master's soul.

תורת ה' תמימה משיבת נפש: Torah restores the soul, giving you energy for life.

Saadia adds: "I'm more exalted than discussing these stupid examples. I shouldn't even be talking to you about this, only because I'm afraid people believe these things."

5. "From the four winds." **מארבע רוחות באי הרוח ופחי בהרוגים האלה ויחיו** (Yechezkel 37). They read *ruach* as the soul, blown into dead bodies so that they live again. But "four directions" is about the winds: Hashem calls the wind from all four directions to give life to the bodies. It is a verse about **resurrection**, not reincarnation.

Saadia's summary

1. Soul decomposition is rejected; the soul waits.
2. Four mistakes behind reincarnation: equating oneself with those who think the soul comes from God; animal and human resemblances, though one soul's essence cannot change into another; children's suffering, which is for future reward; and five verses, each easily refuted, "and indeed they are easily refuted."

Part 3: The Rabbi's Survey of Gilgul

In the last twenty minutes, the Rabbi surveyed the history of the idea.

Outside Judaism

The first account we have is from the 5th century BCE. **Pythagoras** and other Greek philosophers believed in reincarnation; Pythagoras said it came from the Egyptians, and that a human soul passes through every kind of animal in a process of about 3,000 years. **Plato** also believed it, and this may be what Saadia means about animal characteristics: Plato said adulterers come back as donkeys, the dishonest as foxes, and good people as bees and ants.

In Jewish sources

"Imagine there isn't the Zohar, okay?" Then there is **no mention of gilgul anywhere** in Tanach, in the Talmud, or in all of rabbinic literature. "To the best of my knowledge, the very first person to bring this concept down is Rav Saadia Gaon, and he only brings it to ridicule it and to disprove it."

- **The Rambam** makes absolutely no mention of it anywhere in his writings, for or against. "He just didn't bother wasting his time with it." We have testimony that **the Rambam's son** wrote that his father did not believe in it.
- **Rishonim who did believe** in it include the **Ramban** in the 13th century, who explains the whole book of **Iyov**, and Iyov's suffering, through gilgul.
- Kabbalists in Spain liked to connect it to **yibbum**: when the brother marries the widow and has a child, the soul of the first husband comes back in that child. Hence **Er and Onan**: Onan "knew that the child won't be his," that it would carry his brother's soul, and so he wasted his seed rather than give Tamar a child.

- **Yosef Albo and Chasdai Crescas**, the Spanish philosophers, reject the whole concept.
- It truly flourishes with **the Arizal**, who told people they were the gilgul of this or that figure. His student **Rabbi Chaim Vital** wrote **Sha'ar HaGilgulim**, full of such identifications: "I saw this woman, and I could see she was a gilgul of that person."

"Then this became accepted and mainstream practice, like many things which the Arizal encouraged became normal things." The Rabbi said he could list ten practices off the top of his head that most Jews assume are required by halachah, which in fact come from the Arizal. Gilgul is "a classical example." People assume it is a fundamental belief, and rabbis preach that if you are bad you will come back as an animal, or even a stone.

The Zohar

"The Zohar is the problem here." If the Zohar was written by **Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai** in the first or second century CE, then there is a rabbinic source for gilgul. But it appears nowhere else, and the Zohar only came to public light around 1290, the claim being that it had been hidden for 1,200 years. The question of its authorship "is a shiur beyond the scope of this evening... It may leave you uncomfortable."

So do Jews believe in reincarnation?

"Depends who you ask." According to Tanach and Talmud, "a flat no." According to the kabbalistic sources, the Arizal and the Zohar, "a certain yes." Is it a fundamental belief? "I think we can all agree it's not." Can those who believe it call one who does not a heretic? "Absolutely not... It's not principles of faith. It's a belief some have, some don't have."

Two extremes

Belz and the Rashash. Belzer Chassidim do not learn the commentary on the Talmud of the **Rashash** (Rabbi Shmuel Strashun of Lithuania), "a beautiful interpretation... really, really nice and clear." Why? The Gemara in **Bava Metzia** explains **ברוך אתה בבאך וברוך אתה בצאתך**: blessed is your leaving the world without sin, just as you came into the world without sin. The Rashash wrote that this is a difficulty for those who believe in gilgul, since a reincarnated soul would come into the world with sin. Because of that, a Belzer Rebbe forbade his Chassidim to study him as a suspected heretic. "That doesn't make sense, in my understanding... You're going to have to not learn the Rambam either. You have to not learn Saadia Gaon."

Breslov. The Rabbi recalled a conversation with a renowned talmid chacham of the Mir who is also a Breslover Chassid. He told him: in Breslov we say, when you go up and are offered the chance to come back as a gilgul, say no, because you may end up doing worse the second time.

The questions it raises

The Rabbi has a whole shiur on how gilgul is supposed to work, for those who believe it: how many times can you come back, and why? How do you know what you came back for? Can you make things worse? And at the resurrection, "your soul is one, your body's two, so which body did you come back into?" "Loads of really bizarre interpretations." But for Saadia, "this conversation is futile because there's nothing to talk about."

Summary

1. **The soul does not decompose** with the body, and it does not "return" to God as a part of Him. It is a new creation that waits, then rejoins the body. The Rabbi warned against teaching children that the soul is "a bit of Hashem."
2. **Reincarnation (העתקה) is not resurrection.** Resurrection is a fundamental belief; reincarnation is not.
3. **Saadia's four mistakes**: it presumes the soul comes from God; animal-human resemblance cannot change a soul's nature; children's suffering is for future reward, not past sin; and five verses misread (Moshe's covenant, Tehillim 1, Iyov's clay, "He restores my soul," the four winds).
4. **History:** Pythagoras and Plato; nothing in Tanach or Talmud; first mentioned by Saadia only to refute it; ignored by the Rambam; accepted by the Ramban; rejected by Albo and Crescas; made mainstream by the Arizal and Sha'ar HaGilgulim; the Zohar is the crux.
5. **Not a principle of faith.** Neither side may call the other heretics.

Coming Up

This completes **Saadia's introduction and the first six essays**. Remaining: Essay 7 on resurrection, Essay 8 on redemption, Essay 9 on the world to come, and Essay 10, "some nice ethics." The shiur resumes a week after Pesach (the Monday after Pesach is Isru Chag) with **Essay 7**. In the meantime: "feel free to review, go over the six essays... so that we'll be clear on Saadia's philosophy before we continue."

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